C L A S S I F I E D T O D E C L A S S I F I E D

THE FIVE MONTHS THAT BROKE THE BLOC

How the CIA Watched Poland's Communist Regime Unravel in Real Time

A Narrative Analysis of Five Declassified Top Secret Intelligence Briefs

April – August 1989

Declassified and Approved for Release: October 29, 2019

Source Documents: TCS 2779/89 • TCS 2815/89 • TCS 2828/89 • TCS 2891/89 • TCS 2892/89

Source Documents at a Glance

The five intelligence assessments analyzed in this narrative were originally classified Top Secret and produced by the CIA's Directorate of Intelligence for the President's Daily Brief and senior policymakers. They were declassified in October 2019. Presented here in chronological order, they chart the collapse of Communist governance in Poland across 134 days.

DATE	REFERENCE	TITLE & SIGNIFICANCE
6 Apr 1989	TCS 2779/89	**Roundtable Accords Signed** *Solidarity legalized; parliamentary elections and new presidency created. The regime gambles on controlled liberalization.*
18 May 1989	TCS 2815/89	**Catholic Church Legalized** *Warsaw grants the Church full legal status—an act of desperation signaling the regime's collapsing ideological monopoly.*
3 Jun 1989	TCS 2828/89	**Election Implications (Special Analysis)** *Pre-election assessment predicting a sweeping Solidarity victory and a deeply polarized post-election landscape.*
17 Aug 1989	TCS 2891/89	**Communists, Solidarity on Collision Course** *Solidarity demands the right to form a government; Jaruzelski and Kiszczak resist but show signs of flexibility.*
18 Aug 1989	TCS 2892/89	**Non-Communist Government To Be Announced** *Jaruzelski capitulates. A Solidarity-led coalition government is agreed. The Cold War's European endgame begins.*

Prologue: Reading the Tea Leaves of Empire's End

In the spring of 1989, the analysts at CIA headquarters in Langley had a front-row seat to something that none of them—nor anyone else in the Western intelligence community—had dared predict with confidence: the peaceful disintegration of Communist power in the heart of Europe. The five documents examined here, all originally stamped Top Secret and produced for the most senior echelons of American government, tell the story of that disintegration in Poland across just 134 days. They are remarkable not only for what they reveal about the events themselves, but for what they reveal about the intelligence community's own evolving understanding of a crisis that was rewriting the rules of Cold War geopolitics in real time.

What makes these documents invaluable to the modern security professional is their rawness. These are not retrospective histories shaped by hindsight. They are assessments written under pressure, with imperfect information, where analysts had to weigh the intentions of Polish generals, the resolve of shipyard workers, the patience of Moscow, and the volatility of a nation teetering between hope and crackdown. The judgments are often cautious, sometimes hedged, occasionally wrong—and always instructive.

Act I: The Gamble at the Roundtable

April 6, 1989 — TCS 2779/89

The first document, dated April 6, 1989, lands with the controlled tone of an analyst who suspects they may be witnessing something historic but isn't yet ready to say so. The Roundtable Accords had just been signed between the Solidarity opposition movement and General Wojciech Jaruzelski's Warsaw government. On paper, the deal looked like a masterpiece of managed liberalization: legalize Solidarity, allow limited parliamentary elections, create a powerful new presidency that the Communists would control, and hope that the appearance of reform would buy the regime the popular legitimacy it desperately needed to push through painful austerity measures.

The CIA's assessment captures the inherent instability of this arrangement with precision. Both sides had entered the agreement with fundamentally incompatible expectations. Solidarity saw the accords as a foothold—a beachhead from which to expand democratic participation and eventually challenge the party's monopoly on political and economic power. The regime saw them as a pressure valve—a way to share blame for economic pain while retaining ultimate control through the presidency, the security services, and the original chamber of parliament.

The structural details are telling. The lower house would remain 65 percent controlled by the Communist Party and its allied satellite parties. Only 35 percent of seats would be contested. But a new 100-seat senate would be entirely freely elected—and it would have the power to veto legislation, subject to a two-thirds override by the lower house. The presidency would carry powers to nominate or dismiss the prime minister, dissolve parliament, and veto legislation. Jaruzelski was expected to be the only candidate.

What the CIA flagged most urgently was the fragility of the deal itself. The official state union, OPZZ, had refused to sign a controversial wage-indexation formula—a signal that the economic components of the agreement were already unraveling before the ink was dry. The analysts noted growing opposition to the accords on both sides: radicals within Solidarity who felt Walesa had sold out at the table, and hardliners within the party who feared the regime had wandered onto the slippery slope of powersharing. Both groups would prove to be correct, though only one of them would benefit from being right.

The assessment also identified what would become a recurring theme across all five documents: the regime's chronic inability to deliver on its own reform commitments.

Warsaw had already failed to keep self-imposed pledges like ending bailouts for insolvent state-run enterprises. Local party bosses and official union leaders were expected to sabotage agreements reached in the capital. This was not a government that inspired confidence in its ability to manage a controlled transition—and the CIA knew it.

Act II: The Regime's Hail Mary

May 18, 1989 — TCS 2815/89

Six weeks later, the CIA reported on what might seem like a footnote in a story about the collapse of Communism—but was in fact a deeply revealing indicator of the regime's accelerating desperation. Poland's legislature had passed a law granting the Catholic Church full legal status. The Pope could now name all bishops without state interference. The Church could own property in its own name. A free Catholic press was authorized. A formal exchange of ambassadors between Warsaw and the Vatican was expected.

The CIA's comment section is worth lingering over. The analysts characterized the move as a clear indicator of desperation. The regime needed popular support immediately—specifically to boost its prospects in the June elections that the Roundtable Accords had set in motion. But the deeper significance, as Langley saw it, was ideological. By recognizing both the political opposition through the Roundtable and the Church through this legislation, Warsaw had effectively abandoned its longstanding claim to rule alone. The Communist Party's four-decade monopoly on Polish political life was being dismantled not by revolution but by the regime's own legislative acts.

There was also a strategic calculation: Warsaw hoped to lure the Church—long supportive of Solidarity—into a more neutral political stance. If the Church could be made a stakeholder in the new system, perhaps it would temper the opposition's demands. It was a reasonable theory, and it was doomed to fail. By confirming the Church's status as Poland's leading moral and political force, the regime had handed its most potent rival a legal framework to operate with even greater authority.

Act III: The Election That Changed Everything

June 3, 1989 — TCS 2828/89 (Special Analysis)

The third document is the most analytically ambitious of the set—a full Special Analysis prepared on the eve of Poland's June 4 parliamentary elections. The CIA's prediction was blunt: a sweeping victory for Solidarity and a deeply divided government. The opposition would fully control the new senate and win most of the contested seats in the lower house. The party's negligible appeal and legitimacy made this outcome essentially certain.

What makes this assessment particularly valuable is its granular attention to the campaign dynamics. Solidarity, after a slow start, had mounted what the CIA described as a Western-style election campaign complete with brass bands, bumper stickers, and stump speeches. Buses in major cities were covered in opposition placards. Solidarity lapel pins were everywhere. Citizens bought campaign coupons and commemorative bricks to finance races. Popular apathy had given way to cautious but growing optimism.

The Communist Party, by contrast, never shed its stilted, rigid public style. Rallies drew only a handful of faithful supporters while opposition events pulled thousands. By mid-campaign, it was evident that the party label alone was enough to doom a candidate. The assessment also noted a telling detail: the regime chose not to make its official list of Communist candidates publicly available—a tacit acknowledgment that being identified as the party's candidate was a political death sentence.

Despite the mismatch, the CIA judged that the election would be relatively fair. The regime understood the consequences of cheating, both domestically and internationally, and was honoring its commitment to allow opposition poll judges and ballot-counting observers.

The postelection analysis was where the assessment turned genuinely prescient. The CIA predicted an uneasy and protracted tug of war. Party officials would count on Jaruzelski's presidency to protect Communist privileges and break the opposition's momentum. The regime would try to maneuver Solidarity into sharing responsibility for painful economic policies while laying groundwork to blame any stagnation on opposition obstructionism. Meanwhile, Solidarity would attempt to build cross-party working relationships on pragmatic issues like housing, environmental cleanup, and agricultural prices—gradually eroding the party's structural advantages from within.

The outlook section contained a warning that proved prophetic: if the opposition failed to implement constructive reforms, it could end up in a stalemate with hardliners determined to protect their control of the economy and the corrupt nomenklatura. That outcome, the analysts warned, would leave the populace more disillusioned and angrier than ever. The stakes of this democratic experiment were not just political—they were existential for Poland's social stability.

Act IV: The Collision

August 17, 1989 — TCS 2891/89

By mid-August, the tug of war the CIA had predicted was reaching its breaking point. The fourth document, dated August 17, reports that Solidarity had reversed its earlier, more conciliatory position and was now insisting that its sweeping election victory and the public's demand for change entitled it to form a new Polish government. This was no longer a negotiation about ministerial portfolios. This was a demand for power.

Solidarity's leadership said they would offer the Communists the sensitive ministries of Defense, Internal Security, and possibly Foreign Affairs—a concession designed to reassure Moscow and the security establishment. Solidarity's legislative leadership proposed Lech Walesa as their candidate for prime minister, though he declined the position.

The regime's response was revealing. President Jaruzelski and Premier Kiszczak—who between them controlled the military and security forces—continued to claim that a Solidarity-led government was unacceptable. But the CIA's analysts detected flexibility beneath the rhetoric. Kiszczak had offered to resign and suggested that the leader of the United Peasant Party, a minor satellite of the Communists, be named premier instead. This was not the behavior of a regime preparing to crack down. This was the behavior of a regime looking for a face-saving exit.

Jaruzelski was expected to meet with leaders of the various political groups to seek a way out. The CIA assessed that he might try to delay by proposing a Communist reformer or an independent-minded member of a small allied party to head a transitional government. But the analysts also noted that Solidarity leaders were sensitive to enormous public pressure for fundamental change and were unlikely to back down unless genuinely convinced that Jaruzelski would take drastic action—such as dissolving the legislature entirely.

The implicit question hanging over the entire assessment was whether the security forces would intervene. The CIA noted that elements within the military and security services were already urging a crackdown. But the analysts' tone suggested they assessed this as a

bargaining chip rather than a likely course of action. The regime was bluffing—and Solidarity, reading the room, was calling the bluff.

Act V: The Capitulation

August 18, 1989 — TCS 2892/89

Just one day later, the fifth document landed on desks in Washington with news that would have been unthinkable twelve months earlier. After meeting with parliamentary leaders, President Jaruzelski had agreed to a landmark coalition government led by a non-Communist and dominated by Solidarity. The crucial choice of prime minister would be announced soon.

The details were extraordinary. Jaruzelski had accepted a Solidarity proposal for the opposition, along with the United Peasants' and Democratic Parties, to form a coalition government committed to reform. The Communists would apparently retain the Internal Affairs and Defense ministries—their last bastions of institutional power. Walesa hinted he might accept the prime ministership to promote stability, but Jaruzelski was reportedly considering several other candidates, including Solidarity caucus leader Bronislaw Geremek and union leader Tadeusz Mazowiecki.

The CIA's comment section captured the significance with measured understatement. Any deal between Jaruzelski and Walesa, the analysts noted, would almost certainly be cleared with Moscow and would be widely accepted as a reasonable way out of the current crisis. The assessment predicted that hardliner resistance at a Communist Party Central Committee plenum scheduled for the following day could prolong the crisis, but judged that Jaruzelski probably expected to prevail in any showdown with party traditionalists.

Two observations in this final document deserve particular attention from modern security professionals. First, the regional implications: the CIA noted that the prospect of a non-Communist government had drawn a cautious reaction elsewhere in Eastern Europe. Hungary, already on its own liberalization path, claimed such a government would not threaten the Warsaw Pact and could actually accelerate Hungary's progress toward multiparty elections. The domino theory, so long invoked to justify containment, was about to work in reverse.

Second, the economic reality that awaited the new government: the CIA assessed that only a Solidarity-led government would have enough popular credibility to convince the nation to make the painful sacrifices needed for economic reform. But Solidarity had not yet fashioned a coherent reform program and would probably renew its calls for a US-led Marshall Plan for Poland, potentially seeking as much as $10 billion to buy time to forge a

consensus on reforms. The democratic revolution had been won—but the harder work of democratic governance was about to begin.

Lessons for the Modern Security Professional

Read together as a single narrative, these five documents offer lessons that extend well beyond the specific context of Cold War Europe. They illuminate patterns that recur wherever authoritarian systems attempt managed liberalization, wherever regimes miscalculate the forces they have unleashed, and wherever intelligence analysts must assess the trajectory of political upheaval under conditions of radical uncertainty.

1. Controlled transitions rarely stay controlled

The Roundtable Accords were designed by the Polish regime as a pressure valve. Instead, they became a breach in the dam. Every concession—legalizing Solidarity, creating a freely elected senate, granting the Church legal status—was intended to strengthen the regime's legitimacy. Each one instead accelerated the erosion of its authority. The lesson is structural: once an authoritarian system acknowledges the legitimacy of alternative power centers, it cannot easily re-establish its monopoly. The CIA tracked this dynamic in real time but, like the regime itself, consistently underestimated the speed of the unraveling.

2. The gap between intelligence and foresight

These assessments are impressively well-sourced and analytically rigorous. Yet they also reveal the inherent conservatism of institutional intelligence analysis. The CIA repeatedly hedged its predictions, emphasizing the possibility of crackdown, stalemate, and regime resilience—even as the regime was visibly collapsing. This is not a criticism; it is a feature of responsible analysis. But it is a reminder that the most consequential developments in international security often fall outside the range of outcomes that cautious analysts are willing to predict. The boldest scenario—a peaceful transfer of power from a Communist regime to a democratic opposition—was treated as improbable right up until the moment it happened.

3. The decisive role of individual judgment under pressure

Every one of these documents revolves around the decisions of individual leaders—Jaruzelski, Walesa, Kiszczak, Geremek, Mazowiecki. Structural forces created the conditions for change, but human choices determined the outcome. Jaruzelski's habitual slowness to decide, noted explicitly in the August 18 brief, could have led to paralysis or crackdown.

Walesa's decision to stand above the political fray while his lieutenants negotiated preserved both his credibility and his flexibility. These are not just historical curiosities. They are reminders that political transitions are ultimately governed by the courage, calculation, and character of the people at the center of them.

4. The morning after the revolution

The final document's acknowledgment that Solidarity lacked a coherent economic reform program is perhaps the most sobering lesson of all. Democratic transitions are celebrated for their political drama, but their success or failure is determined by what comes next: the unglamorous work of building institutions, implementing reforms, and managing the expectations of a population that expected liberation to deliver prosperity. Poland would ultimately succeed in this challenge through the Balcerowicz Plan and eventual EU accession. But many subsequent democratic transitions around the world would fail precisely where the CIA's analysts identified the risk—in the gap between revolutionary legitimacy and governing competence.

Epilogue: What the Stamps Tell Us

There is something clarifying about reading documents that once carried the Top Secret classification stamp. These assessments were written for an audience of perhaps a few dozen people—the President of the United States, the National Security Advisor, the Secretary of State, and their closest aides. The analysts who wrote them understood that their words could shape American policy toward a crisis that might tip either toward democracy or toward tanks in the streets. That weight of consequence is visible in every careful hedge, every qualified prediction, every measured observation.

Thirty-five years later, these documents serve a different purpose. They are primary sources for understanding not just what happened in Poland in 1989, but how the most powerful intelligence apparatus in the world processed, interpreted, and communicated that information to decision-makers. For security professionals today—whether they are analyzing political transitions in post-Soviet states, democratic backsliding in emerging economies, or authoritarian consolidation in rival powers—these five briefs offer a masterclass in the art and limitations of strategic intelligence.

The story they tell is ultimately a hopeful one: a nation that found its way from martial law to multiparty democracy without a shot being fired, through a combination of exhausted authoritarianism, organized opposition, institutional flexibility, and no small amount of individual courage. It is also a cautionary one: a reminder that even the best intelligence analysis can only illuminate the path ahead. Walking it remains the work of the people who live in the countries where history is being made.

ABOUT THIS ANALYSIS

This narrative was synthesized from five declassified CIA intelligence documents (C06826736, C06826742, C06826743, C06826757, C06826758) approved for public release on October 29, 2019. All source material was originally classified Top Secret. The analytical commentary and narrative framework are original work; the underlying facts and assessments are drawn directly from the declassified record.